

The Water Cycle

The water cycle describes how water moves continuously through the Earth and atmosphere.

It is powered mainly by energy from the Sun and by gravity.

Evaporation is the process by which liquid water turns into water vapor. The Sun heats water in oceans, lakes, and rivers, and this warmth gives water molecules enough energy to rise into the air as an invisible gas.

Condensation happens when water vapor cools high in the atmosphere and changes back into tiny liquid droplets. These droplets gather together to form clouds.

Precipitation occurs when the water droplets in clouds grow large and heavy enough to fall back to the surface as rain, snow, sleet, or hail. Gravity pulls this water down.

Collection is the final stage, where fallen water gathers in oceans, lakes, rivers, and underground aquifers, ready to begin the cycle again.